

Week 6 Lit Example Reader

JULIUS CAESAR: VALID FORM, UNPROVED PREMISE

Purpose: Julius Caesar passages for Week 6: separate validity from truth and soundness. A valid argument can still fail if a premise is false, doubtful, or unproved.

What to watch for: Brutus can use a valid form; Antony challenges the factual pressure point. Run form first, fact second.

Before the Passages: The Week 6 Logic Tool

- **Form test:** If the premises were true, would the conclusion have to follow?
- **Fact test:** Are the premises actually true, adequately supported, or at least reasonable?
- **Sound argument:** valid form plus true premises.

Do not call an argument sound simply because the conclusion sounds important. Do not call it invalid simply because a premise is doubtful. Keep the two tests separate.

Passage 1: Act 3, Scene 2 — Brutus's Valid-Looking Defense

Context: Brutus tells Rome why Caesar was killed. The speech can be reconstructed in a valid form, but the form does not prove every premise.

Brutus. If then that friend demand why Brutus rose against Caesar,
this is my answer:—Not that I loved Caesar less, but that I
loved Rome more. Had you rather Caesar were living and die all
slaves, than that Caesar were dead, to live all free men?
As Caesar loved me, I weep for him; as he was fortunate, I rejoice
at it; as he was valiant, I honour him: but, as he was ambitious,
I slew him. There is tears for his love; joy for his fortune;
honour for his valour; and death for his ambition.
Who is here so base that would be a bondman? If any, speak;
for him have I offended. Who is here so rude that would not be a Roman?
If any, speak; for him have I offended. Who is here so vile that
will not love his country? If any, speak; for him have I offended.

Reader Notes

Here is your most assisted example. Brutus's argument can pass a form test if reconstructed this way: All men whose ambition would enslave Rome deserve death for Rome's freedom; Caesar was a man whose ambition would enslave Rome; therefore Caesar deserved death for Rome's freedom. If both premises are true, the conclusion follows. But the minor premise still needs the fact test.

Reading task: Mark Brutus's conclusion. Box the premise about Caesar's ambition. In the margin, write: form test or fact test?

Passage 2: Act 3, Scene 2 — Antony's Fact Test

Context: Antony does not mainly say Brutus's form is invalid. He gives reasons to doubt whether Caesar fits Brutus's pressure-point premise.

Antony. The noble Brutus
Hath told you Caesar was ambitious:
If it were so, it was a grievous fault,
And grievously hath Caesar answer'd it.
He was my friend, faithful and just to me:
But Brutus says he was ambitious;
And Brutus is an honourable man.
He hath brought many captives home to Rome
Whose ransoms did the general coffers fill:
Did this in Caesar seem ambitious?
When that the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept:
Ambition should be made of sterner stuff:
Yet Brutus says he was ambitious;
And Brutus is an honourable man.
You all did see that on the Lupercal
I thrice presented him a kingly crown,
Which he did thrice refuse: was this ambition?
Yet Brutus says he was ambitious.

Reader Notes

Antony's evidence does not automatically prove the opposite of Brutus's claim. It may make the claim doubtful. That distinction matters. A premise can fail the fact test because it is false, but it can also fail because the speaker has not given enough evidence for it.

Reading task: Number Antony's evidence. For each item, write whether it proves Caesar was not ambitious or merely gives a reason to doubt Brutus's charge.